

AP Spanish Language & Culture: The Complete Exam Guide

The new project-based exam explained: the presentation and Q&A, the argumentative essay, listening and reading, and 10 practice questions in Spanish.

Hi, I'm **Pigo!** I'll drop tips all through this guide.



~2:30 hrs

fully digital exam
in Bluebook

55+3

multiple-choice +
free-response tasks

35%

of your score comes
from your project

83–85%

scored 3 or higher
in recent years

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THE EXAM AT A GLANCE

Your project, plus skills

The exam now centers on a research project you complete during the year about a Spanish-speaking community. Your score (1–5) combines speaking about that project, writing, and listening and reading.

20%

Project presentation

15%

Project Q&A

15%

Argumentative e...

50%

Multiple choice • 55 Q

Exam structure

Section	Weight & timing	What you do
Q1 • Project presentation	20% of score 3 min prep + 3 min speaking	Deliver a spoken presentation in Spanish answering the project prompt, using your Personalized Project Reference (PPR).
Q2 • Project Q&A	15% of score 4 questions • 40 s each	Answer four pre-recorded questions about your project research.
Q3 • Argumentative essay	15% of score 55 minutes	Write a persuasive essay on a question using three sources with different viewpoints: two print sources and one audio source (heard twice).
II • Multiple choice	50% of score 80 min 55 questions	Listening: 25 questions (40 min, 25%) on audio sources • Reading: 30 questions (40 min, 25%) on print texts.

FULLY DIGITAL

Everything happens in Bluebook

You answer every question, including the written responses, in College Board's **Bluebook** testing app. Responses are submitted automatically at the end. Practice typing timed answers before May.

BEFORE EXAM DAY

Submit your PPR by late April

Your **Personalized Project Reference** is a structured outline of your research and sources. Submit it in the AP Digital Portfolio by the late-April deadline; you can see it during the presentation.

How to use this guide

Just starting?

Read pages 2–6, then follow the roadmap on page 8 month by month.

Mid-year?

Check the traps on page 7 and drill the free-response playbook on page 6.

Exam in weeks?

Take the 10 questions on page 9 in 15 minutes, then use the final-four-weeks plan.

SECTION II

02 Listening & reading

55 questions in about 80 minutes. Listening questions use authentic audio such as interviews, podcasts and announcements; reading questions use articles, ads, charts and literary texts.

25

listening questions on audio sources

30

reading questions on print sources

50%

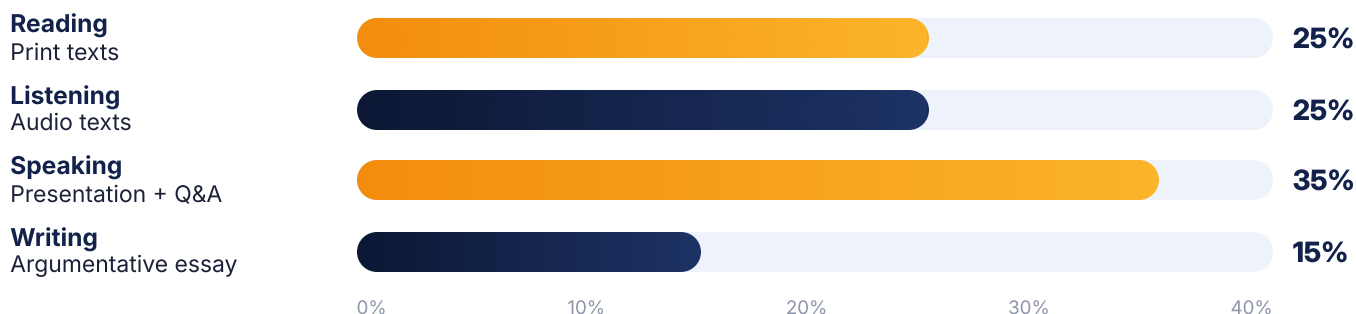
of your total AP score

0

points lost for a wrong answer, so never leave one blank

◆ How your score is built

Share of the total exam score for each skill.

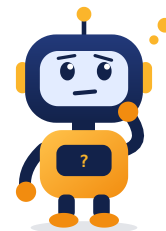


What this means for your study time: Speaking about your project is the single biggest part of the exam (35%). Listening and reading together are half, so daily exposure to authentic audio and texts matters.

◆ Strategies that work on this section

- ◆ **Preview the questions** before each audio plays, so you know what to listen for.
- ◆ **Take short notes** while listening: names, numbers, opinions and the main idea.
- ◆ **Read the introduction line** of each text; it tells you the source and purpose.
- ◆ **Don't translate word for word.** Use context to infer meaning of unknown words.
- ◆ **Watch for paraphrase.** Correct answers rarely repeat the text's exact words.
- ◆ **Never leave a blank.** There is no penalty for guessing.

Listen to **Spanish podcasts or news** for 10 minutes a day. It trains your ear for natural speed.



03 WHAT THE COURSE COVERS

The 6 themes & the project

Course content is organized into six themes. Your project connects research to one of them, using authentic sources in Spanish.

THEME

1

Families & Communities

Explore: family values, traditions and how communities are changing in Spanish-speaking communities.

THEME

2

Language & Culture

Explore: how language, media and technology shape identity and cultural expression.

THEME

3

Art & Creativity

Explore: how art, music and literature reflect a community's history and values.

THEME

4

Science & Technology

Explore: how scientific and technological change affects daily life and society.

THEME

5

Contemporary Life

Explore: education, work, leisure, popular culture and changing lifestyles.

THEME

6

Global Contexts

Explore: how global issues such as the environment, migration and health affect communities.

◆ The course project, step by step

1 • Research

Investigate the project prompt using authentic Spanish-language sources.

2 • Build your PPR

Create your Personalized Project Reference: a structured outline of findings and sources.

3 • Submit

Upload the PPR to the AP Digital Portfolio by the late-April deadline.

4 • Present

On exam day, present for 3 minutes and answer 4 questions about your research.

SECTION I

04 The free-response tasks

Two spoken tasks about your project, then one argumentative essay.

Presentation · 20%

Q&A · 15%

Essay · 15%

Free response = 50% of your AP score

Q1

Project presentation

3 min prep · 3 min speaking

Answer the project prompt using what you learned. Organize clearly: introduction, main findings with examples from your sources, and a conclusion.

Practice timing: aim for 2:45–3:00 so you use the full time.

Q2

Project Q&A

4 questions · 40 seconds each

Respond to four recorded questions that ask you to explain, extend or reflect on your research.

Answer directly in the first sentence, then add one detail or example.

Q3

Argumentative essay

55 minutes

Read two print sources, listen to an audio source twice, then write a persuasive essay that takes a position and cites all three sources.

State your thesis in the first paragraph and cite each source by number.

Tip

Using sources well

Essay success

Synthesize the sources: compare viewpoints, use them as evidence, and explain how each supports your position.

Don't just summarize each source in turn.

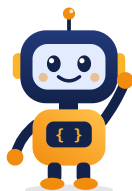
● Presentation: your 6 minutes

Review PPR
1 min

Plan points
2 min

Present
3 min

Use the preparation time to choose two or three key findings and an example for each.



Use **linking words** and a range of tenses. Variety in your speaking raises your score.

FREE-RESPONSE PLAYBOOK

05

Anatomy of a strong presentation

Here is a short sample of a strong project presentation opening, annotated to show what earns points.

PRACTICE TASK • WRITTEN BY ACT SAT GO

Practice prompt (project presentation style): How do traditional markets help communities preserve their cultural identity? Use what you learned in your research about one Spanish-speaking community.

Sample presentation opening

- ① Hoy voy a hablar de cómo los mercados tradicionales ayudan a las comunidades a conservar su identidad cultural, en particular en la Ciudad de México.
- ② Según un artículo que leí, más de la mitad de los vendedores del Mercado de San Juan trabajan en negocios familiares que tienen más de cuarenta años.
- ③ Además, estos mercados no son solo lugares para comprar: allí las familias comparten recetas y celebran fiestas locales.
- ④ Por eso, creo que los mercados funcionan como "museos vivos" de la cultura mexicana.

- ① **Clear introduction** that answers the prompt.
- ② **Specific finding** with an example from a source.
- ③ **Connectors** that organize ideas.
- ④ **Cultural insight** beyond simple facts.

Five habits for every speaking and writing task

- 1**
Answer the question in your first sentence.
- 2**
Use connectors to organize ideas.
- 3**
Vary tenses and sentence structures.
- 4**
Self-correct briefly, then keep going.
- 5**
Use every second of speaking time.

06 LEARN FROM OTHERS

10 traps that cost points

Meet **Glitch**. He lives in these ten mistakes. Squash each one before May.

Just **memorize** your presentation! (Careful.)



01 A memorized script

The presentation should sound natural. Know your findings well rather than reciting word for word.

02 Missing the PPR deadline

Without a submitted Personalized Project Reference, you won't have your outline during the presentation.

03 Too short

Stopping at 1:30 of a 3-minute presentation limits your score. Use the full time.

04 Ignoring the Q&A question

Answer exactly what is asked first; then elaborate.

05 Long silences

Use fillers in Spanish and keep going rather than stopping.

06 Only one tense

Showing past, present and future tenses demonstrates range.

07 Word-for-word translation

Think in phrases, not single words, to avoid unnatural sentences.

08 Summarizing sources

Use sources as evidence for your position rather than summarizing them.

09 Skipping notes while listening

Brief notes on names, numbers and opinions make audio questions much easier.

10 Cultural facts without insight

Explain what a practice or product shows about a community's perspectives.

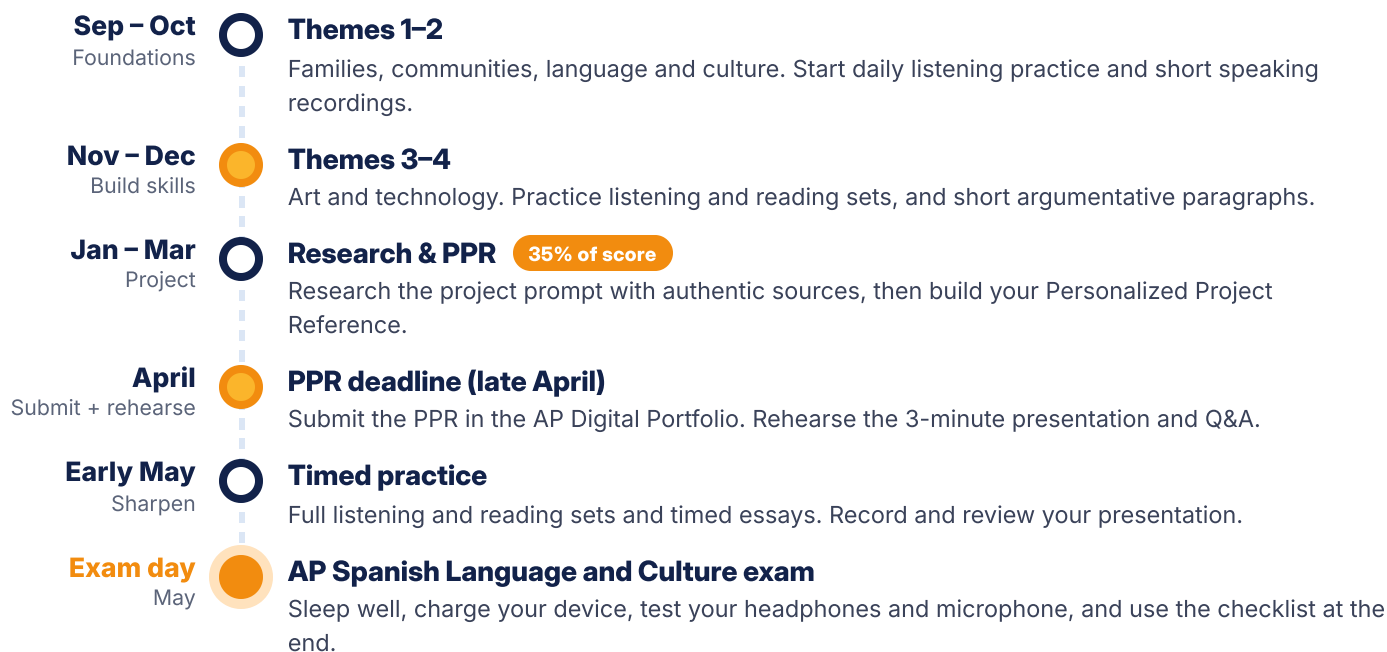
Quick self-check: can you speak about your project topic in Spanish for three minutes using the past, present and future tenses and at least five connectors (además, sin embargo, por eso...)?



PLAN YOUR YEAR

Your study roadmap to May

A steady plan beats a last-minute rush. Schedule your project research early so the PPR is ready well before the late-April deadline.



◆ The final four weeks

Week	Focus	Target
4 weeks out	Diagnose: one listening and one reading set	Name your weaker skill
3 weeks out	Daily: 10 min listening, one recorded presentation run	Use the full 3 minutes
2 weeks out	Full practice exam under timing	Finish every task
Final week	Light review: PPR, connectors, Q&A practice	Rest the night before

08 TEST YOURSELF

10 practice questions

Original reading and language questions written by ACT SAT GO in the style of the exam, pitched at the harder end. Explanations on the answer page are in English. Give yourself **15 minutes**, then check page 11.

1 LECTURA · IDEA PRINCIPAL

Lee el texto y responde las preguntas 1–4.

En muchas ciudades latinoamericanas, los mercados tradicionales compiten hoy con los supermercados y las aplicaciones de entrega. Sin embargo, el Mercado de San Juan sigue lleno cada sábado. "Aquí no solo compras comida", explica doña Rosa, que vende frutas desde hace treinta años. "Conoces a tus vecinos, aprendes recetas y mantienes vivas las tradiciones de tu familia". Aunque los precios a veces son más altos, muchos clientes jóvenes prefieren apoyar a los pequeños productores locales.

Texto original escrito por ACT SAT GO para práctica

¿Cuál es la idea principal del texto?

- A Los mercados tradicionales siguen siendo importantes porque fortalecen la comunidad y las tradiciones.
- B Los supermercados han reemplazado a los mercados tradicionales.
- C Doña Rosa quiere vender su negocio.
- D Las aplicaciones de entrega son más baratas que los mercados.

2 LECTURA · VOCABULARIO

En el texto, la palabra "compiten" sugiere que los mercados tradicionales:

- A colaboran con los supermercados
- B tienen que atraer clientes frente a otras opciones
- C han cerrado
- D venden los mismos productos que las aplicaciones

3 LECTURA · INFERENCIA

Según el texto, ¿por qué algunos clientes jóvenes eligen el mercado?

- A Porque los precios son siempre más bajos
- B Porque no tienen teléfono
- C Porque doña Rosa es su abuela
- D Porque quieren apoyar a los productores locales

4 LECTURA · PROPÓSITO

La cita de doña Rosa sirve principalmente para:

- A dar datos económicos sobre el mercado
- B criticar a los clientes jóvenes
- C mostrar el valor social y cultural del mercado desde la experiencia personal
- D explicar cómo funcionan las aplicaciones

5 GRAMÁTICA · SUBJUNTIVO

Completa: "Es importante que los jóvenes ___ las tradiciones de su familia."

- | | |
|-------------|--------------|
| A conocen | B conocieron |
| C conocerán | D conozcan |

08 TEST YOURSELF (continued)

6 GRAMÁTICA • PRETÉRITO / IMPERFECTO

Completa: "Cuando yo ___ niño, siempre ___ al mercado con mi abuela."

- A era / iba
- B fui / fui
- C era / fui
- D fui / iba

7 CONECTORES

¿Qué conector expresa mejor un contraste? "Los precios son altos; ___, muchos prefieren el mercado."

- A por lo tanto
- B sin embargo
- C además
- D por ejemplo

8 REGISTRO • CORREO FORMAL

¿Qué saludo es más apropiado para un correo a la directora de un museo?

- A ¡Hola, amiga!
- B ¿Qué tal, profe?
- C Estimada señora directora:
- D Oye, directora:

9 CULTURA • COMPARACIÓN

En un ensayo, ¿qué oración muestra mejor una perspectiva cultural (no solo un dato)?

- A Muchas familias ven el mercado como un espacio para transmitir valores entre generaciones.
- B El mercado abre a las ocho.
- C El mercado tiene cien puestos.
- D El mercado está en el centro.

10 GRAMÁTICA • CONDICIONAL

Completa: "Si tuviera más tiempo, ___ en el mercado los sábados."

- A trabajo
- B trabaje
- C trabajé
- D trabajaría

09

CHECK YOUR WORK

Answer key & explanations

Read every explanation, even for questions you got right. Each one points to a pattern that keeps coming back on the exam.

#	Answer	Why
1	A	The text explains that, despite competition, the market stays full because it builds community and preserves traditions.
2	B	"Compiten" (they compete) means the markets must attract customers against supermarkets and delivery apps.
3	D	The last sentence says many young customers prefer to support small local producers, even when prices are higher.
4	C	The quotation gives a personal view of the market's social and cultural value (neighbors, recipes, traditions).
5	D · conozcan	"Es importante que" expresses an impersonal judgment, which requires the present subjunctive.
6	A · era / iba	Both describe background and habitual past actions, so both take the imperfect.
7	B · sin embargo	"Sin embargo" (however) introduces a contrast between high prices and customer preference.
8	C	"Estimada señora directora:" is the formal greeting suitable for a professional email.
9	A	Perspectives explain attitudes and values (transmitting values between generations), not just facts.
10	D · trabajaría	A hypothetical "si" clause with the imperfect subjunctive (tuviera) takes the conditional in the result clause.

9–10

Strong. Move on to full timed free-response practice.

6–8

On track. Revisit the unit behind every miss on page 4.

0–5

Build foundations now. Read and listen to Spanish every day, and practice speaking for three minutes without stopping.

10 KNOW THE TARGET

How students score

In recent years, about 83–85% of students earned a 3 or higher on AP Spanish Language and Culture, and about 21–22% earned a 5. Steady preparation is what moves a score up a full point.

83–85%

of students earned a 3 or higher in recent years

21–22%

earned the top score of 5 in recent years

3+

is the score many colleges accept for credit or placement

What each AP score means

5

Extremely well qualified

4

Very well qualified

3

Qualified

2

Possibly qualified

1

No recommendation

Ranges reflect recent College Board score distributions and shift a little each year. Credit and placement policies vary by college, so check each college's AP policy.

Exam-day checklist

- ☐ **Bluebook** is installed and updated, and your device passed the exam check
- ☐ Device **fully charged**, with the charger packed
- ☐ Admission ticket and photo ID, as your school requires
- ☐ Confirm your **exam day and start time** in May with your AP coordinator
- ☐ Your **PPR was submitted** in the AP Digital Portfolio before the late-April deadline
- ☐ **Headphones and microphone** tested for the speaking and listening sections
- ☐ Answer **every** multiple-choice question. Wrong answers don't lose points
- ☐ Review your PPR and practice the presentation once the night before

In the free-response tasks: answer every prompt directly, organize ideas with connectors, show a range of vocabulary and tenses, use the full time, and explain cultural perspectives, not just facts.



ACT SAT GO • 1-ON-1 AP TUTORING

Aiming for a 5? Get a personal AP Spanish plan.

Book a free diagnostic lesson. We'll find your weakest units, review your practice responses, and give you a week-by-week plan to exam day in May.

Book a free diagnostic lesson →



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Spanish conversation practice

Live 1-on-1 speaking sessions to build fluency for the presentation and Q&A.

Project & writing skills

Argumentative essay coaching and research-skills support. Your project stays 100% your own work.

Listening & reading practice

Timed sets with authentic audio and texts, so you see progress before May.

◆ Contact us

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